

Prologue

At 05:12 the city still pretended it was calm.

Izzy walked as Saskia Klein.

Union Node spilled commuters into the underway. Watch halos pinged green in soft waves. The floor arrows adjusted in real time, herding bodies toward the least expensive corridor, the least risky corridor, the corridor that made the model happy.

Izzy let her watch face stay dark and read the world the way Baylight did: thresholds, queues, coverage cones, exits.

A transit gate accepted her with the smallest sound—a clean click—and her watch flashed:
VERIFIED / GREEN.

No delay, no questions, no polite extra lines. The gate only read the plate layer; Saskia Klein stayed green as long as nothing deeper asked for provenance.

Behind her, a courier in a soaked vest tapped twice. His gate went yellow. The new line appeared under it like an apology dressed as policy:

MANUAL REVIEW PENDING.

On the overhead panel, the courier's route reassigned itself before he even stepped aside; a punctuality strike posted to his shift app, small enough to call administrative, big enough to cost lunch.

Izzy felt the old cold in her ribs.

She'd helped write the weighting that made hesitation look like intent. She'd called it fraud reduction in the meeting notes. She'd shipped it as a patch.

At HarbourSpire, in a glass room that smelled like citrus wipes and hot displays, she had watched a case review where her patch flagged a home-care worker as serial fraud because he kept buying infant formula off-route after midnight. A vice president called the eviction that followed a precision correction. The slide deck logged the family's instability as reduced leakage. Izzy had sat there with her badge on and said nothing until the silence started following her home.

She could have kept walking.

Instead, she thumbed open a buried courtesy menu on her watch and burned a one-use priority surety into the courier's queue. Traceable credits. Traceable mercy. The kind Baylight could audit later and call collusion if it wanted to.

Her watch answered a beat later with a private haptic and a line she had not seen in years:

COURTESY OVERRIDE LOGGED.

Beneath it, in smaller type:

CREATOR EXCEPTION QUOTA: 0

The old backdoor had just burned itself, and Baylight now had a clean trace of the shape of her mercy.

No more Saskia Klein in reserve. No last green lane if a plate went yellow, no private budget of doubt she could spend to stay invisible. She had not opened a creator lane; she had spent the last scrap of one, and the cold under her ribs spread like the city had finally noticed she was standing in it.

In this city, plates and gates ran on fast trust—watch signals that decided where you could move, work, and be seen.

Beneath that sat escrow credentials like the spine cartridge: cold, court-legible hardware you could hold in your fist—an authority layer the infrastructure could honor even when the interface denied you. Under the Storm Safety Order, those layers were allowed to disagree, and enforcement always followed the most restrictive reading.

The gate tone didn't turn green, but the timer shortened. The courier looked up in surprise. Izzy was already moving before thanks could become memory.

At the top of the stairs, a vendor cart glowed with Verified plates—soft green halos on steel. A woman slid her watch near the reader and paid without looking up. The cart's screen smiled back:

THANK YOU FOR YOUR COOPERATION.

The cart's plate recalculated the price as her wrist hovered:

STORM RISK SURCHARGE: +1.5 CREDITS.

The vendor didn't apologize. The number was the apology.

Across the lane, a city cleaner in orange watched his shift board reroute him three stops east and add a storm reliability penalty if he declined. He tapped ACCEPT without reading the fine print all the way through.

At the apartment entrance beside the cart, a tenant's plate stalled on a cheerful notice:

TENANCY REVIEW / LIABILITY HOLD (TEMPORARY).

before the lock finally clicked. From the sidewalk, Izzy saw the woman clutch a grocery bag to her chest and slip through the entry the moment the plate turned green.

A courier's public watch halo dimmed from green to gray after one missed attestation prompt. Nobody stared for long. In the Sprawl, even looking too closely at someone else's downgrade could become a kind of data.

Her watch stayed green. Her name stayed Saskia. The city kept moving.

The city could know more about her than it could yet act on.

That was what "clean" meant in the Sprawl: not innocence—throughput.

Izzy turned south toward the Viaduct, taking the routes that stayed busy enough to blur her edges. Above, concrete ribs held up the highway and held in the sound. Below, the under-city breathed wet air through grates.

Her jaw port hummed beneath the thin seam along her jaw—a hairline of darker skin that caught the light when it was active—the quiet itch of maintenance deferred. She could feel the timer even when she couldn't see it.

One more block. Two.

The moment she stepped under the Viaduct's shadow, her glasses banner forced itself on—bright, centered, polite as a bill.

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